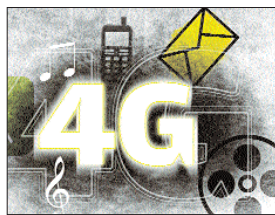




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The Geek's Pickings

In Internet time, we need round-ups to remind us about what happened when. So here's what just happened...

Ram Mohan Rao

Some heads here at *Digit* fumble when asked to name the Prime... umm, Chief Minister of our own state. But we sure know our E3 and U3 from our T3. So, even as magazines with important-sounding names like "Time" and "India Today" are gearing up for their yearly round-up, covering such topics as... umm... actually, we're not sure... we're doing our own round-up of the year that's been, in terms of what really matters—storage, sound, software, and such—in seven categories.

We've graduated from obsessing over frogs and snails and puppy-dogs' tails, but we're still little boys deep down. We're so innocent, things like terabyte hard disks and potential pod-party-poopers excite us. Here's our list of Stuff You Care About—you can always Google "chief minister of (your) state" later!

STORAGE

We've been inching ever so much closer to terabyte territory. And we're more than halfway there: 500 GB hard disks are available at your local store. We knew in 2005 that this would come to pass this year, courtesy perpendicular recording.

That technology was pioneered by Seagate, and as you might know, it promises considerably

higher areal densities. In perpendicular recording, the magnetic "domains" that hold the bytes are oriented perpendicular to the plane of the platter, as opposed to the old way, where they were on the plane. Such a seemingly small change paves the way for a goodish upgrade—up to ten times the capacity! The first 750 GB drive shipped this year in May. Kudos to Seagate!

Samsung surprised us with "hybrid" hard drives for laptops: they showed off prototypes in April. These hybrids have 1 GB of Flash goodness, and the drive is asleep most of the time—cutting down on power consumption by something in the range of 50 per cent! What happens is, the Flash works while the drive sleeps, and when it fills up, the drive wakes, copies the data, and happily slumbers again.

We're just dying to get our hands on one of these for our Desktops, too! And we won't have to wait long, it seems—January 2007 for the developed world, and sometime later for us Indians.

Jaded as we've become with price drops, Flash is one area that hasn't failed to surprise.